A Handbook for Living

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Written by six voices

There is something in a man that recognizes before it is taught.

Loss

The coffee was ready before he was.

He stood at the counter and watched it fill his cup, the way it did every morning, the way it would tomorrow.

He wrapped both hands around it. The cup was too hot for that but his hands did it anyway, the way they always did, and the warmth went through his palms into the bones of his fingers.

The window over the sink was the gray that comes before the light decides. He could see the yard — the fence, the shape of the tree, the gate that still needed the hinge he kept meaning to fix. Inside, the counter held what counters hold: the toaster pushed back against the wall, the fruit bowl with two soft apples, the notepad with a grocery list in handwriting that was not his.

He drank. Not a sip — the kind of long pull a person takes when the coffee is still too hot and he does it anyway, because his body is done waiting for his mind to catch up. The heat went down his throat and into his chest and he felt his shoulders drop — not relax, just drop, the way a thing drops when it has been held too long without anyone deciding to hold it.

He looked down at the cup. Half gone. The steam had stopped rising — or maybe it was still rising and the kitchen had gotten warm enough that he could not see it anymore. He did not know which. It did not matter which. The coffee was cooling. The window behind him was lighter now, not light, but the gray had shifted the way it does when you are not watching it, when you look up and something has changed and you cannot say when it changed because you were holding a cup and the cup was the whole world for however long the cup was the whole world.

He rinsed the cup and set it in the rack, upside down, the way someone had taught him once, though he could not remember who. The water ran for a second after he turned the faucet off. Then it stopped.

Tuesday

The alarm went off at the same time it always did.

The room was still dark and the sound was in it. The body under the covers did not move the way a body does not move when it has been awake for longer than the alarm — awake in the dark, awake before the sound, awake the way a person is awake when sleep has left without saying when it left. Then the hand found the button and the sound stopped and the room was dark again, but a different dark, the dark after a sound, which is not the same as the dark before it.

The feet found the floor before the rest of him agreed to it. The left one and then the right and the cold came up through the wood the way cold comes — without asking, without waiting — and for one second the body was only a body sitting on the edge of a bed with its feet on a cold floor, and that second was the truest

thing, truer than the dark and truer than the sound that had been in it, because the cold does not know what happened and the feet do not know what happened and the floor is just the floor and it holds what is placed on it.

He stood the way a person stands when standing is not a decision — the legs straightened and the floor took the weight and the hallway was there, the dark length of it, and at the end of it a sound. Not the alarm. A different sound. A door opening and feet, smaller feet, and then she was in the hallway in the shirt she slept in, holding a shoe in one hand, and she said, "I can't find the other one," and her voice was the first voice of the morning that was not his, and he said, "Check by the door," and his voice worked, and the surprise of it — that the instrument still played, that the mouth still made the sounds a father makes — went through him the way the cold had gone through the floor, without asking, and then she was past him and he was walking toward the kitchen because the kitchen was where the morning happened and the feet knew the way.

She found it by the door where shoes collect, and he sat on the bottom step and she put her foot in his lap the way she always did and he pulled the tongue straight and laced it, the left loop and the right loop and the pull, and the knot was the ordinary thing, the most ordinary thing his hands knew how to do, and they did it the way they had done it every morning for three years — without thinking, without looking up, the fingers finding the lace and the lace finding the loop and the loop pulling tight the way a knot pulls tight when the hands have made it so many times the hands are the knot — and she was off the step and gone before he had let go, pulling the door with both hands, her whole weight behind it, and the morning came through it and he was still sitting on the step holding the shape of where the shoe had been.

His hands closed on nothing. Then they opened, and he stood, and the hallway was bright now with the door still open and the morning in it, and his feet took him to the kitchen the way feet take a person to the place where the next thing is, not because the person has decided but because the kitchen is where the bread is and the bread is what the hands do next.

The bread was where the bread always was. The hands opened the bag and took two slices and set them on the counter and the counter was the same counter and the knife was in the same drawer. Turkey from the package, folded once. The cheese she liked, torn at the corner where the wrapper always tore. The second slice pressed down flat the way the hands always pressed it — not hard, just flat, the way bread gets pressed when the hands have made this sandwich enough times that the pressing is not a decision but a shape the palms remember. The knife wiped on the towel. The towel left on the counter.

The apple was next. The hands knew. Cutting board, the small one, the blade finding the stem and going through and the apple falling open the way apples fall open — white and ordinary and already starting to brown at the edges, the way the air gets at a thing the moment the skin is broken. Quarters. The stem side down, the blade finding the center the way the blade always found the center, and the quarters went into the bag and the bag was on the counter and the hands were reaching for the next thing and then they were not.

The eyes had looked up. Not because anything called them. The window was there the way the window was always there, above the sink, and the light was in it now, full light, not the gray from before but the light that comes when the morning has finished arriving, and the yard was in the light — the fence, the tree, the gate with the hinge — and for one breath the person standing at the counter was only a person standing at a counter in a lit kitchen

with a knife in one hand and nothing in the other, and the yard was not asking anything, and the tree was not asking anything, and the breath was not a pause because the hands had not stopped, the hands had just — there was a moment, not even a moment, less than a moment, when the weight was the same weight but the hands were not under it, and the light was in the window and the window held the light the way the counter held the bread — because that is what it was for, because it had always been for that — and then the breath finished and the apple was in the bag and the bag was on the counter and the hands were reaching for the next thing.

The next thing was the pad by the phone. The hands tore a square from it — the same pad, the list in the other handwriting still there, curling at the corner the way paper curls when it has been waiting — and the pen was where the pen always was and the hand wrote "have fun" and folded the square once and put it in the bag between the sandwich and the apple, and the pen went back and the bag was zipped and the bag was by the door.

The hands had nothing left to do. The bag was by the door and the counter was wiped and the kitchen was finished with him or he was finished with the kitchen and the hands hung at his sides the way hands hang when they have forgotten they are hands. The light from the window was on the floor now, a square of it, warm where it fell on the tile, and he was standing in it the way a person stands in light when the light is where they happen to be — not meaning to, not choosing it, just standing where the morning had put him. The square was warm. The hands were empty. The house was quiet the way a house is quiet when everyone has left it except the person who stays, and the quiet was not the dark from before — it was the quiet after the morning has done its work, the quiet of a kitchen that has made a lunch and tied a shoe and written two words on a pad and is finished now, and the person standing in it was not finished but the kitchen did not need him to be finished,

the kitchen only needed him to stand in the light, and the light did not ask if he was ready, and then his hand reached for the keys on the hook and the keys were cold the way the floor had been cold and the door opened and the morning came in.

The Commute

The door closed behind and the street was there. Not the morning coming in — the morning already in, everywhere, on the pavement and in the sound of it, the buses and the walking and the ordinary weight of a city at the hour when everyone is going to the place they go. The feet knew the way. They had always known the way — left to the sidewalk, the block and a half to the corner, the light that was always red when the feet arrived and green by the time the feet were ready, as if the city and the body had worked this out between them long ago, an agreement neither one remembered making.

The coffee shop was on the corner the way it was always on the corner. The line moved. The person in front was holding a phone and a bag and the bag was slipping and the hand caught it the way a hand catches a thing that is slipping — without looking, without deciding, the hand just catching — and the line moved again and

then it was the counter and the face behind the counter was a face that had been there before, not every morning but enough mornings that the face was familiar the way a street is familiar, not by name but by shape, and the mouth behind the counter said "the usual?" and the mouth said "yeah, thanks" and the hands found the wallet and the card and the machine made the sound it makes.

And that was it. That was the whole encounter. The usual. Yeah, thanks. The card. The sound. And the person moved to the side where the drinks collect and waited the way everyone waits — the phone, the window, the nothing that a person looks at when the person is between one thing and the next thing — and the cup appeared with a name on it that was close enough and the hand took it and the mouth said "thank you" and the mouth behind the counter was already saying the next thing to the next person and the door was there and the street was there and the cup was warm the way the other cup had been warm, the first cup, the kitchen cup, except this cup had a name on it that someone else had written and the warmth was the same warmth and it was not the same warmth.

The cup was in the hand and the hand was in the cold and the cold was where the morning lived now, outside the shop, on the sidewalk where the walking was. The steam from the cup went up and the breath went up and they were the same thing for a second, the cup's heat and the body's heat leaving at the same speed, and the sidewalk was full the way sidewalks are full at this hour — not crowded, just full, everyone going, everyone carrying something, a bag or a phone or a cup or nothing, and the nothing was carried too, the empty hands swinging at the sides of people who were walking the way the feet walk when the feet know where they are going.

A woman came the other way. Not fast, not slow, the speed of someone who is also going to the place they go. The sidewalk was wide enough for both of them but not wide enough for both of

them without one of them moving, and the body moved — not a step, less than a step, the shoulder turning the way a shoulder turns when the body knows another body is coming and the concrete is shared and the sharing does not need to be discussed. She passed. Close enough that the coat sleeve brushed the coat sleeve, or almost brushed, or the air between the sleeves moved the way air moves between two things that almost touch. And her face was a face — not a shape, not a blur, a face, seen for less time than it takes to blink, with eyes that were going somewhere and a mouth that was closed and a jaw that was set the way a jaw is set when the cold is on it, and the seeing was not a meeting and not an ignoring. It was the thing that happens between two people on a sidewalk who are both carrying everything and showing nothing and the nothing passes the nothing and both keep walking.

The cup was still warm. The hand adjusted its grip — not because the cup was slipping but because the hand does that, the hand shifts, the fingers resettle, the way a body resettles in a chair it has been sitting in for a long time, not because anything is wrong but because the body is always finding its way back to the weight, always adjusting to what it is holding, and the holding is not a decision the hand makes, the holding is what the hand is.

The building was where the building always was. The door opened the way doors open in buildings that know you — not with a key but with a pull, the weight of it familiar, the lobby with the same light it always had, the elevator with the same sound. The cup was almost empty now. The hand held it anyway, the way a hand holds a thing that has stopped being useful but the hand has not yet found the moment to let it go.

The hallway was the hallway and someone was in it. Not a stranger — a person with a name and a face that had been in this hallway on other mornings and would be in this hallway on mornings after this one. And the person said something. Not the

words — the words were the same words everyone says in a hallway in a building in the morning, the "hey" or the "morning" or the "how are you," and the mouth opened and the half-second was there.

Not a pause. No one would have seen it. The half-second between the question arriving and the answer leaving, and in that half-second the whole morning was in the hallway — the alarm in the dark, the feet on the cold floor, the shoe in the lap, the sandwich and the apple and the note and the square of light and the door closing and the street and the traffic light and the coffee and the cup and the name that was close enough and the woman whose coat sleeve almost touched and the steam and the cold and the walking, all of it, the entire morning, everything the body had carried from the bed to this hallway — and the mouth said "good, thanks" and meant it.

And it was true. The mouth was not lying. The morning was good. The thanks was real. The person in the hallway smiled the way people smile when the answer is the right answer and the hallway is the hallway and the morning is doing what mornings do, and then the person was past and the hallway was empty again and the feet kept walking toward wherever the feet were going and the cup was still in the hand, empty now, and the hand held it anyway.

The desk was where the desk always was. The chair rolled back when the body sat, the small wheels on the carpet making the sound they always made, and the body adjusted — the back against the back of the chair, the arms on the arms of the chair, then forward, the elbows on the desk edge and the hands reaching for the keyboard the way hands reach for what they know. The screen had been sleeping and now it was not. The light from it was different from the window light and different from the hallway light and different from the light on the sidewalk — it was close

and blue and it asked something specific and the eyes gave it what it asked.

The empty cup was on the desk, to the right, where the cup always went. The hand had put it there the way the hand puts things where things go, without looking, without choosing the spot, the cup finding the ring on the desk where other cups had been, the pale circle that was not a stain but a record, the way a path across a yard is not a ruin but a record of all the feet that went the same way because the way was the right way and the feet knew.

Around the desk, other desks. Other chairs. Other sounds — the keyboards and the phones and the small throat-clearings and the shift of bodies in chairs, the ordinary percussion of people doing what Tuesday asked them to do. And none of it was the kitchen and all of it held the way the kitchen held — not with warmth but with task. The task was the room's kindness. The task said: here is what your hands do next. And the hands did it.

The screen held what the screen was asked to hold. The hands moved on the keyboard the way hands move when the work is the kind of work the hands know — not hard, not easy, the kind that asks the fingers to go to the right places and the fingers go, and the going is the same going as the laces and the bread and the knife through the apple, the hands doing what the hands do, and the doing was enough, and the morning was underneath the doing the way a floor is underneath a carpet — not hidden, not gone, just covered, and the feet do not feel it and do not need to feel it and the carpet is not lying about the floor, the carpet is doing what carpet does, which is to let the feet walk without feeling every seam.

Someone said something across the room. Not to the person — to the room, the way people speak in rooms where everyone is working, a question about a time or a date or a file, and someone answered, and the answer was ordinary, and the ordinary settled over the room the way the morning had settled over the street,

the way the street had settled over the sidewalk, layer after layer of ordinary, each one covering the one before, and the covering was not concealment. The covering was Tuesday. Tuesday is what the morning becomes when the morning has done its work and the hands have done their work and the wound has found the place underneath the carpet where it can rest without being seen and without needing to be seen — not healed, not gone, resting the way a wound rests under anything that holds it — because the room is full of carpets and under every carpet is a floor and the floors are holding.

The hand reached past the cup for the mouse and the cup was there and the hand did not see it and the cup did not move and the ring on the desk held the cup the way it had always held the cup and the morning was in it — not the coffee, the coffee was gone — the morning, the whole morning, the dark room and the cold floor and the shoe and the laces and the bread and the apple and the note and the door and the street and the light and the steam and the name and the sleeve and the hallway and the good thanks and the good thanks and the good thanks — all of it in an empty cup on a ring on a desk and the hand reaching past it for the mouse because the hand had work to do and the work was there and the hand did it.

The Glass

The cup was where the cup always was.

The hands found it the way they always found it — the left hand on the handle, the right hand on the side where the ceramic was hottest, and the heat was there, the way it was always there, and the hands reported it, the way hands report what hands are holding, and the report was correct, and the warmth did not arrive.

Not cold. Not numb. The hands felt the heat and the heat was real and the body received it the way a desk receives a memo — stamped, noted, filed. The heat went into the palms the way heat goes into palms, through the skin and into the tissue and toward the bone, and somewhere between the tissue and the bone it became information. The hands knew the cup was hot. The person holding the cup did not feel the cup was hot. Both were in the same kitchen. Both were in the same body. The body had not failed. Something

between the hands and the person had thickened overnight, the way glass thickens — not shattering, not cracking, just thickening — and the morning was on the other side of it.

The window was the same window. The yard was the same yard — the fence, the tree, the gate with the hinge. The light was doing what the light does, which is to arrive without asking whether anyone is ready for it, and the light arrived and the kitchen received it and the person standing at the counter received it too, the way a person receives light when the person is standing where light happens to be, which is to say: without receiving it at all. The light was on the counter and on the cup and on the hands and the hands were on the cup and the cup was hot and the person was watching all of it from behind the glass and the glass did not have a name and did not need a name because the glass was not a thing that had arrived. The glass was what was left when everything else continued and the person did not continue with it. The morning moved. The person stayed.

The hands did what the hands did. The left hand released the handle and the right hand kept the cup and the cup went to the mouth and the mouth drank the way the mouth drinks when drinking is what the mouth does next, not because the person wanted to drink but because the hands and the mouth had been doing this for long enough that the wanting was not required, the way the feet do not require the decision to walk, the way the lungs do not require the decision to breathe, and the coffee went down the throat and into the chest and the chest was the same chest and the heat went where heat goes and the person noted the heat the way a person notes a clock — seen, registered, not felt. The shoulders did not drop. The shoulders did not hold. The shoulders were there the way shoulders are there on a morning when the body is doing everything right and the person inside the body is reading the body's report and the report says: the coffee is hot, the kitchen is warming, the shoulders are where shoulders are. And

the person reads the report. And the report is accurate. And the morning is on the other side of the accuracy.

The person set the cup on the counter. Not in the rack — on the counter, still half-full, the handle pointing the wrong way, the way a cup gets set down when the hands are not finishing a task but interrupting one, when the hands have stopped doing what the hands do and the stopping was not a decision but a failure of the next thing to arrive. The hands had always known the next thing. Rinse the cup. Set it in the rack. Upside down. The way someone taught you once. But this morning the hands set the cup on the counter with coffee still in it and the handle pointing toward the window and the hands did not know why the hands had stopped and the person did not know why the hands had stopped and the cup sat on the counter the way a cup sits when it has been set down by hands that forgot what comes next — not because the next thing is gone but because the hands, for the first time in four mornings, are not sure the next thing is theirs to do.

The hallway was there. It had been there for three chapters and it would be there tomorrow and the feet could have gone down it the way the feet always went down it, toward the kitchen, toward the bread, toward the sandwich and the apple and the note. But the feet did not go. The feet stayed where the cup had been set down, near the counter, in the kitchen that was already the kitchen, and the person was standing in the kitchen the way a person stands in a room they have been standing in for years and have just noticed. Not the room. The standing. The fact of it — two feet on the tile, the weight on the left one the way the weight always sat on the left one, and the right one slightly forward because the body leans toward what the body intends to do next, and the body was leaning but the person was not going anywhere.

The window held the yard. The yard held the fence. The gate still needed the hinge. All of it the same — the tree, the light, the

way the shadow from the fence fell across the path to the gate — and the seeing was there, the seeing had been there since the cup was in the hands, and the seeing was not the gift and not the wound. The seeing was the thing that happens when the glass is clean enough to see through and too thick to reach through. The person saw the yard. Every blade, every shadow, every rung of the fence in the early light. The seeing was detailed and precise and it was the seeing of a person standing behind a window watching a yard the person is inside of. Not outside — inside. The feet were on the tile. The tile was in the kitchen. The kitchen was in the house. The house was in the yard. And the person could not get from the feet to the yard without passing through the glass, and the glass was between every layer, between the feet and the tile, between the tile and the kitchen, between the seeing and the seen. The glass was not a wall. The glass was a thickness in the going-through, and the going-through had been so easy for three chapters that the thickness was the only new thing in the room.

She was in the hallway again. He heard her — or his ears heard her, the way his hands had felt the cup, receiving the report. The smaller feet on the wood. The sound of a drawer opening in a room down the hall. A voice — her voice, the one that had said "I can't find the other one" on another morning that felt like it belonged to someone else — calling something, not to him, to the house, the way children call to houses when they are looking for a thing and the house is where the thing should be. And the person standing in the kitchen heard the calling and knew what the calling was asking and knew where the thing was — it was always in the same place, the place things collect by the door — and the mouth opened to say "check by the door" and the words were there, the words had been there for three years, the same words, and the words came out and they were the right words and the voice carried them down the hallway and the voice was correct and the hallway received the

words the way the hands had received the heat and the voice did not feel the words leave.

That was the glass. Not between the person and the cup. Between the person and the voice. The mouth saying the right thing and the saying not costing anything and the not-costing was not freedom. In Chapter 2 the surprise was that the instrument still played. This morning the instrument played and the person heard it playing and the hearing was the report and the report said: the voice works, the words are right, the child will find the shoe. And the report was accurate. And the voice had done what the voice does. And the person standing in the kitchen had spoken to the child the way a person speaks to a child when the person loves the child, and the person did love the child, and the love was on the other side of the glass with the warmth and the yard and the morning, and the person could see the love the way the person could see the yard — through the window, clearly, every detail — and could not reach it.

She found the shoe and she was in the kitchen doorway holding it, not both of them, just the one, the other already on, and she stood the way she always stood when she needed the laces tied — one foot forward, the shoe held out, not asking with words because the asking had never needed words, the asking was the shoe and the foot and the doorway and the morning, and the person in the kitchen saw the shoe the way the person had seen the cup and the yard and the light, clearly, from behind the glass, every detail — the scuff on the toe, the tongue already folded the wrong way, the laces trailing.

The person sat on the step. The same step. The same motion — the lowering of the body, the knees bending, the back finding the angle it always found — and she put her foot in the lap the way she always did and the shoe was in the hands and the hands knew what to do. The hands had always known what to do. The tongue

pulled straight. The lace found the first eyelet and the second and the fingers tightened the way fingers tighten when the fingers have done this so many times the tightening is not a thought but a shape the muscle remembers, and the left loop came around and the right loop came through and the pull — the pull that had been the most ordinary thing, the knot that the hands were — and the knot was correct. The knot was tight. The knot would hold all day the way it held every day and the hands had done what the hands do and the person had tied the shoe and the person had not felt the lace.

Not numb. The fingers felt the lace. The fingers reported: cotton, frayed at the tip, the left one shorter than the right because the left one always broke first. The report was accurate. The lace was in the fingers and the fingers were making the knot and the knot was the same knot and the person was watching the fingers make it the way a person watches hands that belong to someone else, hands that know what they are doing, hands that do not need the person to be in them for the knot to hold. The knot did not need the person. The knot needed the fingers and the lace and the morning and the muscle memory of three years of mornings and the fingers had all of it and the person had none of it and the knot held.

She was off the step before the hands had finished letting go. The way she always was — the whole weight behind the door, the morning coming through it, the hallway bright, the sound of her going, the going that did not look back. And the person was sitting on the step holding nothing, the way the person had sat on this step in Chapter 2 holding the shape of where the shoe had been, except this morning the person was not holding the shape. This morning the person was not holding anything. The hands were in the lap and the lap was empty and the hands were empty and the emptiness was not grief. In Chapter 2 the hands closed on nothing and then they opened. This morning the hands did not close. The hands stayed open the way hands stay open when the hands do not

know they are open, when the hands have finished the task and the task is gone and the hands have not yet found the next task and the opening is not a choice — the opening is what happens when there is nothing to close on.

The step was cold the way the floor had been cold in Chapter 2, through the cloth, into the legs, the kind of cold that does not announce itself as cold but as fact, as the world's temperature arriving without asking. And the person sat in the cold the way a person sits in a fact — not resisting it, not welcoming it, just sitting in it because the body is on the step and the step is cold and the child is gone and the morning is in the hallway and the person is not in the morning.

The person stood. Not the way a person stands when standing is a decision — the way a person stands when the step has been cold long enough and the legs straighten because legs straighten. The hallway was bright with the door still open and the morning was in it and the person walked into the morning the way a person walks into a room they are already in — without entering, without arriving, just the feet moving because the feet move and the kitchen was behind and the hallway was ahead and the body went where the body goes.

The bread was where the bread always was. The hands opened the bag. The hands took two slices and set them on the counter and the hands did all of it — the turkey folded once, the cheese torn at the corner, the second slice pressed flat — and the doing was the same doing and the hands were the same hands and the person watched the hands the way the person had watched the fingers on the lace, from behind the glass, receiving the report. The report said: the bread is on the counter, the sandwich is being made, the hands are doing what the hands do. And the report was correct. And the person read the report. And the sandwich was made.

The apple was next. The hands knew. They had always known. The cutting board, the small one, the blade finding the stem — and the apple fell open the way apples fall open, white and ordinary, and the person saw it. Not the way the person had seen the cup or the yard or the shoe. The person saw the apple the way a person sees a thing that has just been cut open — the white of it, the wet of it, the place where the blade had gone through and the two halves were lying on the board and the air was already at the edges, already browning, the way the air gets at a thing the moment the skin is broken.

And the hands stopped.

Not a pause. Not a decision. The knife was in one hand and the apple half was on the board and the hands stopped the way hands stop when the eyes have seen something the hands cannot answer. The apple was open on the board and the white of it was turning and the turning was happening now, in the seeing, the browning that begins the moment the inside becomes the outside, and the person was seeing it — not reading the report, not receiving the data, seeing it — the way a person sees a thing when the glass has thinned for no reason, for no reason at all, the way glass thins — not shattering, not cracking, just thinning, the way it thickened, without cause, without effort, without the person doing anything to deserve the thinning.

The apple was browning on the board. The hands were still. The kitchen was the same kitchen. And for less than a breath — not the half-second from the hallway, not the breath from Chapter 2, something briefer, something without duration, a gap the clock could not find — the person was not behind the glass. The person was in the kitchen with a knife in one hand and an apple browning on the board and the air coming at the white the way air comes at everything eventually and the seeing was not a report. The seeing was the apple. The browning was the seeing. The person and the

apple and the air were in the same room without the glass between them and it lasted less than it takes to say it lasted and then the hands moved. The blade found the center. The quarters went into the bag. The bag was on the counter. The hands reached for the next thing.

The glass was back. Or the glass had never left. The person could not tell whether the thinning had happened or whether the person had imagined the thinning, the way a person imagines they felt the warmth go through when the report said the cup was hot, the way a person imagines the voice felt the words leave when the words were the right words. The apple was in the bag. The quarters were browning in the dark of it. And the person stood at the counter and the hands were reaching for the pad and the pen and the hands wrote what the hands always wrote — the same two words, the same fold, the same place in the bag between the sandwich and the apple — and the person did not know whether the two words meant what the two words had meant on the morning the warmth went through or whether the two words were the report of two words that used to mean something and now meant the shape of the letters and the fold of the paper and the muscle memory of a hand that writes "have fun" because the hand has always written "have fun" and the hand does not need the person to mean it for the hand to write it.

The bag was by the door. The person was in the kitchen. The kitchen was finished with the person or the person was finished with the kitchen and neither of them could tell which, and the hands hung at the sides the way hands hang, and the light was on the floor — the same square, the same tile, the same warmth where it fell — and the person was standing in it and the standing was the report and the report said: you are in the light. And the person read the report. And somewhere in the reading, so far down the person could not find it, the feet felt the warmth on the tile. Not the report of the warmth. The warmth. The tile under the sole and the

sun on the tile and the warmth going up through the foot the way warmth goes, without asking, without the glass, and it lasted the way the apple had lasted — less than a breath, less than a thought, the duration of a thing that happens before the person can notice it is happening — and then the person noticed, and the noticing was the glass, and the glass was back, and the feet were on the warm tile and the person was reading the report of the warm tile and the warmth was on the other side of it again.

The keys were on the hook. The hand reached for them. The keys were cold.

The door opened and the street was there and the street was the same street and none of it had changed and all of it had thickened.

Not the street itself. The street was concrete and curb and the sound of buses at the hour when the city moves everyone to where everyone goes. The street had not thickened. The between had thickened — the space between the feet and the pavement, between the ears and the sound, between the person and the ordinary weight of a city doing Tuesday. The feet stepped onto the sidewalk and the sidewalk was solid the way it had always been solid and the feet reported it — solid, cold, the slight unevenness at the second crack where the root had lifted the concrete — and the report was correct and the feet did not feel the ground.

The block and a half to the corner. The same block. The same half. The feet knew the way they had always known the way, and the knowing was the feet's knowing, not the person's, the way the hands had known the laces and the knife had known the apple — the body doing what four mornings of practice had trained the body to do, the body so faithful to the route that the route did not need the person to walk it. The person walked it anyway. The person was inside the walking the way a letter is inside an envelope — carried, sealed, delivered to the corner without being read.

The light was red. The light was always red when the feet arrived. That was the agreement — the one neither the city nor the body remembered making, the one from Chapter 3, the agreement that was not a contract but an accumulation, the way the ring on the desk was not a decision but a record. And the person stood at the light the way a person stands at a light — the phone, the nothing, the looking at the nothing that a person looks at when the person is between one thing and the next thing — except this morning the between was not the gap between the things. The between was the glass. The person was standing at the light and the light was red and the city was on the other side of the glass doing what the city does, the buses and the walking and the bags and the cups and the breath going up in the cold, and the person was watching all of it — every detail, every breath, every cup in every hand — the way a person watches a city through a window on a morning when the window should not be there.

The light changed. The feet crossed. And in the crossing — in the middle of the street, between the curb the person had left and the curb the person had not yet reached — the person passed someone. Not the woman from Chapter 3. A different person. A person with a bag and a coat and a face that was a face, not a shape, a face with eyes that were going somewhere and a mouth that was closed, and the person passing saw the face and the face saw the person passing and the seeing was the seeing from Chapter 3 — the thing that happens between two people on a sidewalk who are both carrying everything and showing nothing — except this morning the seeing went through the glass. Not because the glass thinned. Not because the person did anything. The face passed and the eyes met for less time than it takes to look away and the seeing did not stop at the glass. The seeing went through it the way the warmth had not gone through the cup, the way the voice had not gone through the hallway — without reason, without deserving, without the person being ready — and the person felt the face.

Not saw. Felt. The way the foot had felt the warm tile for less than a breath. The stranger's face in the middle of the street and the person felt it the way a person feels a thing that is not theirs to feel, a face going somewhere, a morning carried by someone else, and the feeling lasted the length of the crossing and then the curb was under the feet and the person was on the other side and the face was gone and the glass was back. And the returning was not failure, the way the thinning had not been earned. Both of them — the thinning and the returning — were what the morning did, not what the person did.

The coffee shop was on the corner. The line moved. The person waited in the line the way the person had waited in every line, the phone, the nothing, the between, and the cup appeared with a name on it that was close enough and the hand took it and the mouth said "thank you" and the mouth behind the counter was already saying the next thing to the next person and the door was there and the street was there and the cup was warm and the warmth was the report and the report said: warm. And the person carried the cup the way the person had carried the keys and the bag and the morning — inside the envelope, sealed, walking.

The building was where the building always was. The door, the lobby, the elevator, the hallway — all of it the same, all of it arriving the way the street had arrived and the kitchen had arrived and the morning had arrived, which is to say: without the person arriving with it. The hallway was the hallway. Someone was in it — not the same person from Chapter 3, a different person, or the same person, it did not matter which because the mouth opened and the words came out and the words were "hey, morning" and the person in the hallway said something back and the exchange was complete and the exchange had cost nothing and the costing nothing was the glass.

The desk was where the desk always was. The chair rolled back. The body sat. The carpet made the sound it always made under the small wheels — the sound of carpet, the sound of something soft being pressed by something that rolls over it every morning without the rolling knowing the carpet is there and without the carpet minding — and the body adjusted, the back against the back of the chair, the elbows on the desk edge, and the hands reached for the keyboard the way the hands always reached for the keyboard and the screen woke and the light from the screen was close and blue and it asked something specific and the eyes gave it what it asked.

The cup went to the right. The hand put it there without looking, without choosing, the cup finding the ring the way it had found the ring in Chapter 3, the pale circle on the desk where other cups had been, and the ring received the cup the way the ring receives every cup — without distinguishing, without sorting the morning the warmth went through from the morning the warmth did not, the morning the person was inside the holding from the morning the person was reading the report of the holding. The ring did not care. The ring was the record of every morning and the record did not know which mornings the person had been present for. The ring just deepened.

And the hands were on the keyboard and the hands were doing what the hands do and the doing was the carpet — not the carpet on the floor, the other carpet, the one the person had been walking on all morning, the one made of every faithful gesture, every cup held, every lace tied, every word said in a hallway — and the carpet was under the doing the way the floor was under the carpet under the feet, and the person was inside the doing the way the letter was inside the envelope, and the doing was enough, the doing had always been enough, and the person could not feel the doing being enough.

The screen held what the screen was asked to hold. The fingers went to the right places. Around the desk, other desks. Other keyboards. Other bodies in other chairs doing what Tuesday asked them to do, the ordinary percussion, and the person was part of the percussion the way a drum is part of a percussion — struck, sounding, not hearing its own sound. The room was full of people doing Tuesday behind glass and none of them knew the others were behind glass and the not-knowing was not loneliness. The not-knowing was Tuesday. Tuesday is what the glass becomes when everyone is behind it at the same time and the glass has no outside because the inside is everywhere.

The hand reached for the mouse and the hand passed the cup. The same motion from Chapter 3 — the hand reaching past, the cup not seen, the ring holding. But this morning the hand stopped. Not on the cup. Near the cup. The hand was reaching for the mouse and the hand stopped in the space between the cup and the mouse, in the between, in the inch of desk where the ring ended and the mouse pad began, and the hand was in the air above the desk the way a hand hovers when the hand has forgotten what it was reaching for — not the mouse, the hand remembered the mouse, the hand could see the mouse — but the reaching had paused the way the reaching had not paused in three chapters, and the pause was not the apple and not the tile. The pause was the hand seeing the ring.

Not the cup. The ring. The pale circle on the desk that was not a stain but a record. The hand hovered above it and the eyes looked down at it and the person saw what the person had reached past every morning — the circle that had been there since the first cup, deepening with every cup, the wood darkened in a shape no one had drawn, the shape drawn by the cup itself, by the faithfulness of the hand putting the cup in the same place every morning, the faithfulness so ordinary the faithfulness had become invisible, and the ring was the proof that the faithfulness

had happened on mornings the person could not remember and mornings the person had been behind the glass and mornings the person had been inside the warmth — all of them, all of them in the same circle, the same pale darkening, the same record that did not distinguish.

And the seeing was not the thinning of the glass. The seeing was the glass seeing itself. The person looking at the ring was the person looking at the glass from inside the glass, the way a person standing inside a window sees the window for the first time — not through it, at it — and the window is clear and the window is there and the window has been there the whole time and the person has been looking through it without seeing it and now the person sees it and the seeing does not shatter the window. The seeing is the window knowing it is a window. The glass knowing it is glass.

The hand came down. Not on the mouse. On the desk, next to the ring, the palm flat on the wood the way a palm lies flat on a surface when the palm is not doing anything, when the palm is just — on the surface. The wood under the palm. The carpet under the chair. The floor under the carpet. And somewhere under all of it, so far down the person could not find it and did not try to find it, the fire. Still there. Still the order that held whether the person felt the holding or not. The hand on the desk next to the ring was not the hand feeling the fire. The hand on the desk was the hand knowing the fire was there and not being able to feel it and putting the hand down anyway. The way a person puts a hand on a grave — not to feel the person underneath, not to reach through, but to say: I know you are there. I cannot reach you. I am putting my hand here anyway.

The hand stayed on the desk for less than a breath. Then the hand found the mouse. The screen held what the screen was asked to hold. The fingers went to the right places. The cup was on the ring. The ring was on the desk. The morning was in the cup and the

cup was in the ring and the ring was in the desk and the desk was in the room and the room was full of Tuesday and Tuesday was the glass and the glass was the morning and the morning held the person the way the carpet held the feet, without asking whether the person could feel the holding, and the person could not feel it and the person knew it was there and the knowing was not the feeling and the knowing was enough, or the knowing was not enough, and the morning did not need the person to decide which because the morning was the morning and the hands were on the keyboard and the hands were doing what the hands do.

The afternoon was the afternoon. At some point — the person could not say when — the hands had left the keyboard and were in the lap and the room was emptying the way rooms empty at the end of the day, the chairs rolling back, the keyboards going quiet one by one, desk by desk, screen by screen, the percussion slowing until the only sound was the ventilation doing what ventilation does, which is to continue when everything else has stopped.

The cup was on the ring. The cup had been on the ring all day and the person had not looked at it and had not reached past it and had not thought about it because the cup was the cup and the ring was the ring and neither of them needed the person to think about them for them to be there. The coffee inside was cold now — not the cold of the morning, not the cold of the floor or the step, a different cold, the cold of a thing that was hot eight hours ago and has been sitting in a room that does not care whether the thing inside it is hot or cold, the room-temperature cold, the cold that is not cold but the absence of effort, the cold of a thing the heat has finished with.

The hand reached for the cup. Not for the mouse. Not past the cup. For the cup. The fingers closed on the handle — the left hand, the same hand that had held the handle that morning, the same grip, the same curve of the fingers through the ceramic loop

— and the hand picked the cup up off the ring the way a hand picks a thing up when the picking up is what the hand means to do. Not because the next thing required it. Not because the cup needed rinsing or the desk needed clearing or the morning needed finishing. The hand picked the cup up because the hand saw the cup and the seeing was the hand's seeing, not the report of the seeing, and the hand closed on the handle because the hand wanted to close on the handle, and the wanting was the first wanting all day that did not come from the body's faithfulness or the morning's sequence or the muscle memory of four mornings of practice.

The cup was light. The coffee was cold and there was not much of it and the cup was lighter than the hand expected, the way a cup is lighter when you have been carrying the idea of the cup all day and the cup itself weighs almost nothing. The hand held it. Not the way the hands had held the cup that morning — the heat going through without arriving, the report of the ceramic, the glass between the holding and the feeling. The hand held the cup the way a hand holds a thing it has picked up on purpose, the thumb on the rim, the fingers through the handle, the weight of the cup in the hand and the weight was the weight and the hand felt the weight and the feeling was not the report of the feeling. The feeling was the cup in the hand and the hand knowing it was holding the cup and the holding was the holding and the glass was there — the glass was still there, the glass had not thinned, the glass had not shattered, the glass was the same glass it had been all morning — and the hand was holding the cup anyway. Through the glass. Not past it. Not around it. Through it. The way a hand holds a thing it cannot fully feel but holds anyway because the hand has decided to hold it, because the holding is not contingent on the feeling, because the cup is there and the hand is there and the decision to pick it up was the first thing all day the person did that the morning did not do for them.

The person stood. The cup in the left hand. The desk behind. The ring on the desk — the pale circle, still there, still holding every morning, still not sorting. The person walked to the small kitchen at the end of the hall where the sink was and the person held the cup under the water and the water ran over the cold coffee and the cold coffee went down the drain the way cold coffee goes — without ceremony, without meaning, the brown of it thinning to nothing as the water carried it — and the cup was empty and the cup was clean and the person set the cup in the rack by the sink, upside down, the way someone had taught them once, though they could not remember who.

The rack was not the ring. The ring held every morning without sorting. The rack held the cup the way a rack holds a cup — temporarily, until the next person picks it up, until the morning picks it up, until the cup is filled again with something hot that may or may not arrive. The person set the cup down and the setting down was the setting down and the hands were empty and the hands were the person's hands and the glass was there and the evening was there and both of them were in the hallway at the same time and neither of them was going anywhere and the cup was in the rack upside down and the water had stopped and the fluorescent light in the small kitchen was the only light left on the floor and the person turned it off and the hallway was dark the way hallways are dark when the day has finished with them and the person walked toward the elevator and the feet knew the way and this time the knowing was the person's knowing too, or close enough, the way the name on the cup was close enough, the way close enough is not the feeling and not the report but the third thing, the thing between the glass and the warmth, the thing that carries the person home on the evening the morning did not hold.

The Cup

The person was lying in the bed and the blanket was on the person and the warmth of the bed was the warmth of the bed. Not the report of the warmth. Not the glass checking whether the warmth was real. The warmth. The body's warmth in the blanket. The first warmth of the chapter. And the person was in it the way a person is in a warm bed in the dark — not checking, not sorting, not filing. Just warm. Just awake. Just in the dark before the alarm.

And the alarm did not sound. Not because the alarm was broken. Because the body woke ten minutes early and the alarm was set and the alarm would sound and the body was already awake and the person was lying in the dark in the warm bed and for the first time in five chapters the person was awake before the morning started. The morning had not started. The child was still sleeping. The house was still quiet. And the person was in the bed, in the dark, in the warm, and nobody needed anything yet. The laces did

not need tying. The sandwich did not need making. The cup did not need filling. The person was just here. In the dark. Before the first task. And the being-here was not the glass and not the report and not the warmth-returning. The being-here was the being-here. Ten minutes of being in a bed before the morning needed the person to be anywhere else.

The person was lying in the dark the way a person lies in the dark when the person does not know anyone is watching. The dark warm bed before the alarm. The person awake for no reason. The morning not started. The glass not yet needed. And the person — just the person, just the body, just the warmth — lying in the dark.

The kitchen was the kitchen. The light from the window was the light from the window and the light did not know what time it was but the light was there, on the counter, on the tile, on the cup in the rack by the sink where the person had left it the night before, upside down, the way someone had taught them once, though they could not remember who.

The person took the cup out of the rack. The right hand on the rim, the left hand finding the handle through the loop, the cup turning over in the motion of taking it out the way a cup turns over when you take it out of a rack — the turning built into the taking, the way the turning of a key is built into the opening of a door. The cup was right side up. The cup was light. The cup was empty and the empty was not the empty of the chapters before — not the empty that waits to be filled by something the person cannot feel, not the empty that reports its own emptiness — the empty was just the empty of a cup that has been washed and dried and set in a rack overnight and is now in a hand in a kitchen in the early part of a morning.

The person set the cup under the machine and pressed the button and the machine did what the machine does, which is the thing machines do, the sound of water heating inside a thing that

heats water, and the person stood in the kitchen and waited. Not the waiting of the step — not the waiting where the person sits with the weight in the lap and the silence doing what silence does. This was the waiting of a person standing in a kitchen while a machine makes coffee. The small waiting. The waiting that does not know it is waiting because the waiting is just the time between pressing the button and the cup being full and the time is short and the kitchen is there and the window is there and the light is on the counter and the person is standing in all of it at the same time.

The cup filled. The way cups fill — from the bottom, the dark of the coffee rising inside the white of the ceramic, the steam starting before the cup was full, the steam that comes off coffee the way breath comes off a person in cold air, the visible proof that something hot is in something that was not hot a moment ago. The cup filled and the filling took less than a minute and the person stood there for the less-than-a-minute and the standing was the standing and the filling was the filling and neither of them was anything other than what they were.

The person picked the cup up. The steam moved when the cup moved. The person held the cup the way the person had held the cup on the other mornings — the left hand through the handle, the thumb on the rim — but the holding was the holding. Not the holding-that-reports. Not the holding-that-checks-whether-it-is-holding. The cup was hot and the hand was on the cup and the heat was in the hand and the hand did not file the heat. The hand just had it. The way a hand has heat when a hand is on a hot cup in a kitchen in the early part of a morning.

The person drank. The first sip. The coffee that the machine made from the water that the person put in the machine from the tap that the person turned on in the kitchen that the person walked into from the hallway that the person walked down from the bedroom where the person had been lying in the dark before

the alarm. The coffee was hot. The mouth knew it the way a mouth knows hot. Not the report. The knowing. And the knowing went down with the coffee and the person did not notice the knowing going down because the person was drinking coffee in a kitchen in the early part of a morning and there was nothing to notice. There was just the drinking. The way there is just the drinking when a person drinks coffee in a kitchen before the rest of the morning has started.

The person reached for a second cup. A smaller cup, from the shelf above the rack, the cup with the name on it — the child's name, in the child's handwriting from when the child's handwriting was learning to be handwriting, the letters that leaned the way a child's letters lean before the letters know which way to stand. The person set the small cup under the machine and pressed the button and the machine did what the machine does again and the person waited again and the cup filled again and the steam came off again and the person picked the small cup up and set it on the counter where the child would find it.

Not where the person would hand it to the child. Where the child would find it. On the counter, near the edge, near the place where the child's hand reaches when the child reaches for the counter, the height where the child's morning meets the counter's morning, the place the child would find the cup the way the child finds everything — by reaching and the thing being there. The cup was there. The steam was there. The warmth was in the cup and the cup was on the counter and the person had put it there and the putting was the putting and the steam rose from the small cup with the child's name on it and the steam did not know whose name was on the cup and the name did not know the steam was rising and neither of them needed to know. The cup was there. The warmth was there. The morning was filling the kitchen the way the water had filled the cup — from the bottom up, the light getting stronger on the counter, the sounds of the house starting the way a house

starts, one room at a time, the way a city wakes — and the person was standing in the kitchen holding their own cup and the child's cup was on the counter and both cups were full and both cups were hot and the steam from both cups was in the same kitchen air and the air did not sort whose steam was whose.

The feet were in the hallway before the person heard them. Not the feet from the chapters before — not the feet-that-the-person-heard-as-report, not the sound-that-the-ears-filed. The feet were in the hallway and the person heard them and the hearing was the hearing. The small quick sound of a child's feet on wood in the morning, the sound that is not a knock and not a call but a direction — the sound of someone coming toward the kitchen because the kitchen is where the morning is.

She was in the doorway. One shoe on, the other in her hand, the tongue folded the wrong way the way the tongue always folded, the laces hanging. She stood the way she stood — one foot forward, the shoe held out, the whole body leaning into the asking without the asking being a word. The asking was the shoe and the foot and the doorway and the morning.

The person looked at the child.

Not the way the person had looked at the cup or the counter or the light on the tile. Not with the seeing that checks itself. The person looked at the child the way a person looks at a child who is standing in a doorway holding a shoe — which is to say, the person looked at the child. The face was there. The eyes were there. The eyes were looking at the person and the looking was not searching and not asking and not going through anything. The looking was a child looking at the person who ties the laces. The looking said: you are the one who does this. Not in words. In the standing. In the shoe held out. In the one foot forward and the body leaning. The child's whole morning was in the leaning — the getting up, the finding one shoe and not the other, the putting on the one she

found, the walking down the hallway with the other one because the hallway goes to the kitchen and the kitchen is where the person is and the person is the one who ties the laces. The child did not think about this. The child did not sort it. The child walked to the kitchen with a shoe because the kitchen is where the person is. That was the whole thought. The whole morning. The kitchen. The person. The shoe.

The person set the cup on the counter. Not the way the cup had been set on the counter in the chapter before — not the handle pointing the wrong way, not the setting-down-that-was-the-hands-forgetting-what-comes-next. The person set the cup on the counter because the child was in the doorway and the child needed the laces tied and the cup needed to be out of the hands for the hands to do what the hands were going to do.

The person sat on the step. The same step. The lowering — the knees, the back finding the angle. And she put her foot in the lap.

The weight.

Not the weight-that-reports. Not the weight-the-body-files. The weight of a child's foot in the lap of a person who is sitting on a step in a kitchen on a morning. The foot was heavier than it should have been for a foot that size, the way children's feet are always heavier than they should be, the way a child puts a foot in a lap with the whole body behind the foot because a child does not know how to put a foot in a lap without the whole body coming with it, the way a child does not know how to do anything without the whole body, the way a child leans into the doorway with the whole body and walks down the hallway with the whole body and puts the shoe in the hand with the whole body and every single thing the child does is the whole child doing it because the child has not yet learned to do things with only part of herself.

The foot was in the lap. The shoe was in the hand. The person pulled the tongue straight — the small tug, the canvas stiffening and then lying flat. The person's fingers found the first eyelet and the lace went through and the fingers found the second and the lace went through and the tightening was the tightening — the pull that makes the shoe hold the foot, the pull that the fingers know, the pull that has been the same pull on every morning in every chapter — and the person pulled and the shoe tightened around the foot and the foot was in the shoe and the shoe was on the foot and the person made the loop. The left lace around the right. The pull through. The knot.

The knot was tight. The knot would hold. The person knew the knot would hold the way a person knows a knot will hold when the person has tied that knot enough times that the knowing is in the fingers and not in the checking. The person did not tug the knot to test it. The person tied it and the knot was done and the person's hands were on the shoe and the shoe was on the foot and the foot was in the lap and the child was looking down at the person the way a child looks down at a person who is sitting on a step tying a shoe — from above, the face foreshortened, the chin closer than the forehead, the eyes looking down the way eyes look down at something that is being done for them, the not-quite-patience of a child watching hands do a thing the child cannot do yet but will someday, the watching that is not glass and not report but just watching, the way a child watches.

And the person looked up.

Not to check. Not to see if the child was satisfied. Not to receive the face as grace or gift or window. The person looked up because the person was sitting on a step and the child was standing and looking up is what you do when you are sitting and the person you are sitting in front of is standing. The person looked up and the child was there and the child's face was the child's face —

the specific face, this face, the face of this particular child on this particular morning with this particular shoe now tied and the other shoe already on and the morning waiting in the hallway behind her.

The child did something the child had not done in four chapters. The child smiled. Not at the person — at the morning. At the shoe being tied. At the laces being done. At the thing that needed doing being done and the morning being one step closer to the door and the door being one step closer to the street and the street being one step closer to wherever the morning was taking her. The smile was not for the person. The smile was for the fact that the shoe was on and the laces were tied and the morning could continue. The smile was Tuesday smiling at itself.

And the person — the person sitting on the step with empty hands, the hands that had just finished the knot and were now in the lap with nothing in them — the person felt the smile. Not the report of the smile. Not the diagnostic: child smiling, reason: shoe tied, assessment: morning proceeding normally. The person felt the smile the way a person feels a thing that is not for them but lands on them anyway, the way a person standing near a fire feels the heat that the fire is not sending to them specifically, the heat that is just going in all directions because that is what heat does, and the person is in one of the directions. The child smiled at Tuesday and the person was in Tuesday and the smile landed on the person because the person was there.

The person's mouth did something. Not a smile — not yet, not a full one, not the kind that knows it is a smile. A movement. The mouth moved the way a mouth moves when the mouth is responding to something the person did not decide to respond to. The corners. The small pull that is not a decision but a reflex, the reflex that lives in the face the way the knot lives in the fingers, the pull that happens when a child smiles at a morning and the person is in the morning and the child's smile is in the morning and the

morning is in the person's face and the face does what faces do when they are near a smile, which is the same thing that hands do when they are near a fire, which is to move toward it, not because the person decided but because the face is a face and the smile is a smile and the morning is the morning.

She was off the step. The way she always was — the whole body behind the leaving, the foot pulling out of the lap, the weight gone, the going that did not look back because the going was not leaving the person. The going was going toward the morning. The door. The street. The morning that was hers and not the person's and not the kitchen's and not the step's. Her morning. The one that started in the hallway with one shoe on and the other in her hand and now both shoes were on and the morning was ahead and the child went toward it the way a child goes toward a morning — with the whole body, with everything, with the going that is not leaving but arriving at the next thing.

The person sat on the step. The lap was empty. The hands were in the lap and the hands were empty and the emptiness was the emptiness of hands that have finished a task and the task is done and the next task has not arrived and the hands are just hands in a lap on a step in a kitchen where the steam from two cups is in the air and the light is on the counter and the child is in the hallway putting on her coat.

The person stood up. Not the way a person stands when standing is a decision. The way a person stands when the step has been sat on and the child has gone and the morning is in the hallway and the person is going to follow the morning into the hallway because the hallway is where the morning goes next. The person stood and the kitchen was behind and the hallway was ahead and the child was at the door and the child's cup was on the counter — the small cup with the name on it, the steam still rising, untouched — and the person saw it as the person walked past and the person

did not stop. The child would come back to it. Or the child would not come back to it. The cup was there. The warmth was there. And the morning did not need the child to drink the cup for the cup to have been filled.

The bread was where the bread always was. The person opened the bag and took two slices and set them on the counter and the bread was bread and the counter was counter and the setting was the setting. The person's hands did the sandwich the way hands do a sandwich when the sandwich has been made enough times that the making is in the hands — the turkey folded once, the cheese torn at the corner because the cheese tears at the corner, the second slice pressed flat with the palm, the slight give of the bread under the pressing, the pressing that is not hard and not soft but the pressing that closes a sandwich, the pressing that the hands know.

The sandwich was done. Not finished — done. The way a knot is done. The way the filling of a cup is done. The thing that needed doing was done and the hands moved to the next thing because the next thing was there the way the counter was there and the bread was there and the morning was there. The hands did not pause between the sandwich and the apple. The hands went to the apple because the apple was next.

The cutting board. The small one, from the drawer by the sink, the one that fit on the counter between the coffee machine and the edge. The apple from the bowl. The person held the apple the way a person holds an apple when the person is about to cut it — the left hand on top, the fingers curled over the curve, the stem between the first two fingers, the blade in the right hand finding the place beside the stem where the blade always went. The blade went down and the apple fell open and the white of it was there — the wet white, the raw white, the white that starts browning the moment the air touches it because the white was never meant for the air, the white was meant for the inside of the apple, and the

blade is the thing that introduces the inside to the air and the air does what the air does.

The person cut the halves into quarters. Four pieces. The blade through each half, the same place, the same angle, the way the blade knows. The quarters went into the bag — the plastic bag, the one from the drawer, the one the person pulled out the way a person pulls a bag from a drawer, the reaching-in and the pulling-out that is not a decision but a sequence, the drawer and the bag and the reaching all part of the same gesture, the gesture that has been the same gesture on every morning.

The sandwich went in. The apple quarters around the sandwich, in the spaces, the way they fit, the way things fit in a bag when the bag has held the same things enough times that the fitting is in the bag. And the person reached for the pad.

The pad was by the phone. The pen was by the pad. The person picked up the pen and the pen was in the hand and the hand was on the pad and the hand wrote. Two words. The same two words. The same handwriting — the handwriting that is not the child's handwriting, not the letters that lean, but the person's handwriting, the handwriting of a person writing two words on a small piece of paper in a kitchen in the morning. The words were the words. Have fun. The pen made the letters the way the pen makes letters when the pen has been making those letters on that pad in that kitchen on enough mornings that the letters are the pen's letters as much as the person's. The person tore the paper from the pad. The fold — once, down the middle, the way the person always folded it, the crease sharp under the thumb. The note went into the bag, between the sandwich and the apple, in the place where the note goes, where the child's hand would find it at the table or on the bench or wherever the child opens the bag at the time of day when the bag gets opened, the place in the middle of the day when the child reaches in and finds the sandwich and

the apple and the note and the note says what the note says and the child reads it or does not read it and the note does not care which because the note is the note and the words are the words and the fold is the fold and all of it is in the bag.

The person closed the bag. The person set the bag by the door. On the bench, where the bags go, next to the shoes, near the coat hooks, in the place where the morning collects the things the child will carry out of the house. The bag was next to the other things — the coat, the hat if it was cold enough for the hat, the backpack that the child would put the bag into when the child was ready. The person set the bag down and the setting down was the setting down. The hands let go of the bag the way hands let go of a thing they have carried to the place the thing goes.

The child was at the door. The child had the coat on — the person did not see the child put the coat on, the child put the coat on the way children put coats on, in the hallway, in the time between the shoe and the door, in the part of the morning that belongs to the child and not to the person. The backpack was on. The child picked up the bag from the bench and the bag went into the backpack and the child did not open the bag and the child did not check the bag. The bag was in the backpack because the bag was on the bench because the person put the bag on the bench because the bread was in the drawer and the apple was in the bowl and the pad was by the phone and all of it was the morning and the morning was the form and the form was the morning and neither of them announced the other.

The person opened the door. The morning came in — the air, the light, the sound of the street at the hour when the street has people on it going where people go. The child went through the door the way the child goes through doors — the whole body, the going that is forward, the going that does not look back, not because the going is leaving but because the going is going. The

child went down the steps and the steps went down to the sidewalk and the sidewalk went to the corner and the corner went to the street and the street went to wherever the morning was taking the child and the person stood in the doorway and watched the going the way a person watches a child going down steps — with the body in the doorway, with the hand on the doorframe, with the eyes following until the following is not needed because the child is on the sidewalk and the sidewalk is doing what sidewalks do.

The child did not look back. The child has never looked back. Not in this chapter and not in the chapters before. The child goes toward the morning and the morning receives the child and the child is in the morning and the person is in the doorway and the doorway is the place where the person's morning and the child's morning separate, the way a river separates at a rock — not because the river decided to separate but because the rock is there and the water goes around it and the water on one side of the rock is the child's Tuesday and the water on the other side is the person's Tuesday and both of them are the same river and neither of them knows the rock is there.

The person closed the door. The hallway was quiet. The kitchen was behind, the counter wiped, the bread in the drawer, the cutting board in the sink, the pad by the phone with one fewer page. Two cups on the counter — the person's cup, almost empty, and the child's cup, still full, the steam gone, the warmth still in it, the warmth that was going slowly toward the temperature of the room the way all warmth goes toward the temperature of the room, which is the temperature of a thing the heat has finished with, except this morning the warmth was not finished. The warmth was just waiting. The child would come back to it after school or the child would not come back to it and the cup would be there and the warmth would be gone and the person would pour it out and rinse the cup and set it in the rack, upside down, and tomorrow the person would take it out again.

The person walked back through the kitchen. The person picked up the cup — the person's cup, the one with the ring's worth of mornings in it — and drank the last of the coffee. The coffee was not hot anymore. The coffee was the temperature of a cup that has been sitting on a counter while a person made a sandwich and cut an apple and wrote a note and packed a bag and opened a door and watched a child go down the steps. The coffee was the temperature of all of that. The person drank it and the drinking was the drinking and the cup was empty and the person walked to the sink and rinsed the cup and set it in the rack, upside down, next to where the child's cup would go tonight or tomorrow, the two cups in the rack side by side, upside down, drying, waiting for the morning that would turn them over.

The person picked up the bag. The person's bag — not the child's, the child's was on the child's back going down the sidewalk toward the corner. The person's bag, from the hook by the door, the bag with the things the person carries to the place the person goes. The keys from the hook. The coat from the hook. The person put the coat on and the keys in the pocket and the bag on the shoulder and the door was there and the person opened it again and the morning was still there — the same morning, the same air, the same light, the same street — and the person went through the door the way the child had gone through the door. Not the whole body the way the child goes. The person goes through doors the way a person goes through doors — with the pulling-shut behind, with the key in the lock, with the turning that locks, with the checking that the door is locked, with the hand on the knob one more time because the hand checks, the hand always checks. The door was locked. The person went down the steps.

The sidewalk was the same sidewalk. The child was gone — not gone, ahead, at the corner or past the corner or wherever the sidewalk had taken the child in the time it took the person to rinse a cup and put on a coat and lock a door. The person walked the

way the person walks — the feet, the block and a half, the same route, the same cracks in the concrete, the same root that had lifted the second panel. The walking was the walking. The feet on the pavement and the pavement under the feet and the morning around both of them.

The light at the corner was red. The person waited. The light changed. The person crossed. And in the crossing the person passed someone — not the stranger from the chapter before, a different person, or the same person, it did not matter — a person with a coat and a bag and a face that was a face going somewhere. The person passing saw the face and the face saw the person passing and neither of them stopped and neither of them spoke and the seeing was the seeing — two people on a sidewalk in the morning, both carrying everything, both showing nothing, both going where they were going. The seeing lasted the length of the crossing. Then the person was on the other side and the face was on the other side and both of them were on whatever side they were going to and the sidewalk held both of them the way the sidewalk holds everything — without sorting, without asking what anyone is carrying, without knowing which of them is behind glass and which of them is in the morning and whether the morning is different today or the same.

The coffee shop was on the corner. The line. The waiting. The cup with a name on it that was close enough. The person took the cup and the mouth said thank you and the person behind the counter was already saying the next thing to the next person and the door was there and the street was there and the cup was hot and the person carried it the way a person carries a cup — in the hand, toward the place the person goes, on a morning, in the city, on the sidewalk that holds everything.

The building. The door. The lobby. The elevator. The hallway. The desk.

The desk was where the desk always was. The chair rolled back. The body sat. The small wheels on the carpet making the sound they always made. The person's hands reached for the keyboard and the screen woke and the light from the screen was close and blue and it asked something and the eyes gave it what it asked.

The cup went to the right. The hand put it there without looking, without choosing, the cup finding the ring the way the cup finds the ring — the pale circle on the desk where other cups had been, the circle that was not a stain but a record, the record that did not sort, the record that held every morning the same way, the record that deepened without the person watching it deepen. The cup went on the ring. The ring received the cup. The person did not look at the ring. The person did not put a palm on the wood. The person did not pause.

The cup was on the ring and the ring was on the desk and the person was at the keyboard and the morning was underneath the typing the way the floor is underneath the carpet — not hidden, not gone, not behind glass. Just underneath. The way mornings are underneath afternoons and afternoons are underneath evenings and evenings are underneath the mornings that come after. The morning was underneath. The child was on the sidewalk somewhere, or at the school, or at the table opening the bag, and the sandwich was in the bag and the apple was in the bag and the note was in the bag and the child would find the note or not find the note and the note said what the note said and the words meant what the words meant and the person was at the desk and the ring was deepening and the morning was under everything and the person was typing and the typing was the typing and Tuesday was doing what Tuesday does, which is to continue.

The afternoon was the afternoon. The screen held what the screen was asked to hold. The fingers went to the keys and the keys made the letters and the letters made the words and the words

went where the words were supposed to go. The person was at the desk the way a person is at a desk on a Tuesday afternoon — which is to say, the person was at the desk. The work was the work. The email was the email. The meeting was the meeting where the person said the things the person says in meetings and the people in the meeting said the things the people in meetings say and the meeting ended the way meetings end, not with a moment but with a closing, a thanking, a clicking, a returning to the screen that was waiting with the thing the screen was holding before the meeting took the person away from the screen.

The cup was on the ring. The cup had been on the ring for hours and the person had not looked at it and had not reached past it and had not thought about it the way a person does not think about a cup on a desk — because the cup is the cup and the desk is the desk and neither of them needs thinking about. The coffee inside was cold. Not the cold of the morning — not the cold of the tile, not the cold of the step. The cold of a thing that was hot hours ago and has been sitting in a room where the air is the air and the air does not keep things hot. Room temperature. The temperature of everything that sits long enough.

The person did not notice the cold. The person did not pick up the cup and feel the cold and compare it to the hot and file the comparison. The cup was there. The cold was there. The person was at the desk typing and the cup was on the ring cooling and neither of them was paying attention to the other. The way two things in a room can be in the same room without being in each other's room. The person was in the work. The cup was in the cooling. And the ring held both of them — the person's morning and the cup's temperature — without sorting which one mattered.

At some point — the person could not have said when, the way a person cannot say when the afternoon becomes late afternoon, the way the light changes on the desk without anyone marking the

moment the light changed — the chairs around the person started rolling back. One, then another. The sounds of the day ending — the keyboards going quiet, the screens going dark, the coats coming off the backs of chairs, the bags being lifted from the floor beside the desks. The room emptied the way a room empties at the end of a day — not all at once, not with a signal, but in layers. The way a tide goes out. Desk by desk. Screen by screen. Person by person. Until the room was the room and the person was in it and the person was one of the last ones in it and the ventilation was doing what ventilation does, which is continue when everything else has stopped.

The person looked at the cup.

Not the looking from the chapters before — not the looking that filed and assessed and reported. The person looked at the cup the way a person looks at a cup at the end of a day when the cup has been there all day and the person has not looked at it and now the person is looking at it and the looking is just the looking. The cup was there. The ring was there. The ring was the same ring — the pale circle on the wood that held every morning without sorting, without asking which mornings the person was present and which mornings the person was behind glass. The ring did not know. The ring did not need to know. The ring just deepened.

The person reached for the cup. The hand closed on the handle — the same hand, the same grip, the same curve of the fingers through the ceramic loop — and picked it up. The cup was light. The cold coffee was there and the cup was light and the person held it and did not drink it and did not set it down. The person held the cup the way the person had held the cup that morning — both hands now, the left through the handle, the right on the body of the cup — except the cup was cold and the morning was gone and the person was holding a cold cup in a room that was emptying and the holding was the holding.

The person stood. Walked to the small kitchen at the end of the hall. The sink. The water. The cold coffee going down the drain — the brown of it thinning to nothing, the water carrying it, the cup becoming empty, the cup becoming clean. The person set the cup in the rack by the sink. Upside down. The way someone had taught them once.

The rack held the cup. The person's hands were empty. The fluorescent light in the small kitchen was the last light on the floor and the person turned it off and the hall was dim and the person walked back to the desk and the coat was on the back of the chair and the bag was on the floor and the person put the coat on and the bag on the shoulder and the desk was the desk and the ring was on the desk and the ring would be there tomorrow.

The person walked to the elevator. The button. The waiting. The doors opening. The small square of light and the person stepping into it and the doors closing and the descent — the building going up as the person went down, or the person going down as the building stayed still, the descent that is the same descent every evening, the descent that leads to the lobby that leads to the door that leads to the street that leads to the walking.

The street was different from the morning's street. The same street — the same sidewalk, the same cracks, the same root that had lifted the second panel — but the light was different. The light was coming from the other direction. The light was behind the buildings instead of between them. The light was the light of a day that has done what it was going to do and is now doing the other thing, the going-down thing, the thing the light does when the light has been up long enough. The person walked in the going-down light the way a person walks in evening light — with the shadow longer, with the air different, with the day behind and the evening ahead and the walking between them.

The block and a half. The same block and a half. But the other direction — the direction that does not go to the coffee shop and the building and the desk. The direction that goes home. The direction the feet know the way the feet know the morning direction, except the evening direction is the morning direction reversed, the same cracks from the other side, the same root from the other angle, the same sidewalk holding the same person going the other way.

The person walked. The bag on the shoulder. The coat. The air. The person walking in the evening the way people walk in the evening — not toward something the way the morning walks toward something, but toward somewhere. The somewhere that has a door and a hallway and a kitchen and a child in it. The somewhere that the morning left.

The light at the corner. Red. The waiting. The light changing. The crossing. The other side. And then the block — the last block, the block that has the building on it, the building that has the door, the door that has the lock, the lock that has the key in the pocket, the key that the person's hand found without the person telling the hand to find it, the way the hand finds a key in a pocket when the hand has found that key in that pocket on enough evenings.

The steps. Up, this time. The morning went down. The evening goes up. The person went up the steps and the door was there and the key was in the hand and the key went into the lock and the person turned the key and the lock opened and the person's hand went to the knob and the knob turned and the door opened and the hallway was there — the same hallway, the shoes by the wall, the coat hooks, the bench where the bag had been that morning, the bench that was empty now because the child had taken the bag and the bag was at the school or in the backpack or wherever the bag was at this hour of the evening.

The hallway smelled like the hallway. Not a smell the person could name — not dinner, not soap, not anything specific. The smell of a place that has been lived in all day by the people who live in it. The smell of Tuesday in a house. The smell the person did not notice on the mornings because the mornings smelled like coffee and bread and the getting-ready, and the evenings smelled like this — like the house after the house has been the house all day without the person in it.

The person closed the door. The key out of the lock. The coat on the hook. The bag on the bench. And the person stood in the hallway and the hallway was quiet and the house was quiet the way a house is quiet when you first walk in and the house has not yet told you who is home and where they are and what part of the evening has already started without you.

And then the sound.

The feet. Not the person's feet. The other feet — the small, quick, whole-body feet that the person had heard in the kitchen that morning, the feet that came down the hallway before the person heard them, except this time the person heard them first. The feet were somewhere in the house — upstairs, or in the back room, or wherever the child was when the child heard the door — and the feet were coming. The way feet come when a child hears the door and the door means the person and the person means the evening has the other person in it now. The feet came down the stairs or through the hall or from wherever the feet were and the feet were fast the way a child's feet are fast when the child is going toward something the child wants to go toward and the going is the whole body and the speed is the whole body and the child appeared at the end of the hallway the way the child had appeared in the kitchen doorway that morning — suddenly, entirely, the whole child at once, as if the child did not walk to the end of the hallway but arrived there.

The child was running. Not running the way a person runs — not with a destination, not with the legs doing the work and the body following. Running the way a child runs — the body first, the legs catching up, the running that is falling forward and the legs happening to be there to catch the falling, the running that is not speed but direction, the direction being toward, the toward being the person in the hallway who has just come through the door.

The child hit the person's legs. Not hard — not the way a collision is hard. The way a child arrives at a person's legs when the child has been running down a hallway. The arms around the legs. The face against the thigh. The weight — the whole weight, the same whole weight from the morning, the foot in the lap, the whole body behind every gesture — the weight against the person's legs and the person's legs holding the weight the way legs hold a child's weight, which is by being there, by not stepping back, by standing in the hallway while a child presses into them.

The person's hand came down.

Not reaching. Not deciding. The hand came down the way a hand comes down when a child is at the person's legs and the hand is above and the coming-down is what hands do — the way water comes down, the way the evening light comes down, the way a thing that is above a thing it belongs to comes down to the thing it belongs to. The hand came down and found the child's head. The hair. The shape of the skull under the hair. The warmth of the scalp under the hair under the hand. The hand found all of it the way a hand finds what it knows — without looking, without checking, without asking whether the finding is the finding or the report of the finding. The hand found the head and the head was there and the hand was there and both of them were in the hallway and the door was closed behind the person and the evening was in the house and the hand was on the head.

The person stood in the hallway with the hand on the child's head and the child's arms around the person's legs and the hallway was the hallway and the house was the house and the evening was the evening. The person did not bend down. The person did not crouch. The person stood and the hand was on the head and the standing was the standing — not a moment, not a decision, not the climax of anything. The standing was a person in a hallway with a hand on a child's head at the end of a Tuesday. The person was in the hallway the way a lamp is in a room — giving light without knowing it is giving light, the glass and the fire together making the thing the room sees by, the thing the child sees by, the thing the evening holds without asking what it is.

The child pulled away. Not away — toward. Toward the deeper part of the house. The way children pull away from a parent's legs — not leaving but leading, the pull that says come with me, not in words but in the going, the going-deeper that assumes the person will follow because the person has always followed, because the hallway goes deeper into the house and the deeper part of the house is where the evening is and the evening is where the child is going and the person is coming because the person is here and the being-here means the following and the following means the evening.

The person followed. The hallway into the kitchen. The kitchen that was different from the morning's kitchen — the light different, the counter different, the cups not where the cups had been. The child's cup was on the counter — the small cup with the name on it, the cup the person had filled that morning and set where the child would find it. The cup was empty now. The child had found it. The child had drunk it. The cup was empty and the cup was on the counter and the person saw the cup and the seeing was the seeing — not the report, not the filing, not the noticing-the-cup-as-evidence-of-something. The cup was empty because the child had drunk what was in it. That was all. The child had

found the cup and the cup had been warm and the child had drunk it and the cup was empty and the cup was on the counter and the person walked past it into the evening.

The child went deeper into the house and the person followed. Not followed — walked. The person walked into the room where the child was going because the room was where the evening was and the evening was where the person was going and the child was already there the way the child was always already there, ahead of the person, in the room, in the evening, in the part of the day that the person had not been in because the person had been at the desk and on the sidewalk and in the elevator and on the block and a half.

The room was the room. The couch was the couch. The child's things were on the floor the way children's things are on the floor — the backpack open, the papers half out, a shoe by the leg of the table that was not where shoes go but was where this shoe was because the child had taken it off and the shoe had landed where shoes land when children take shoes off, which is wherever the shoe happens to land. The other shoe was by the door. The person had seen it in the hallway. One shoe by the door and one shoe by the table and neither of them next to each other and the person did not say anything about the shoes because the shoes were the shoes and the evening was the evening and the shoes would be by the door tomorrow morning because the shoes were always by the door tomorrow morning, the way things find their way back to where they go without the person always being the one who puts them there.

The child was on the floor. Not the couch — the floor, in the space between the couch and the table, in the spot where the child always was in the evening, the spot that was the child's spot the way the ring on the desk was the person's ring, a place made by use, a place no one assigned. The child had a paper and the child

had a crayon and the child was drawing or writing or doing the thing that children do with paper and crayons in the evening after the day has done what the day was going to do. The person sat on the couch. Not the step. Not the desk chair. The couch, which was the couch, which was where the person sat in the evening, the cushion that had the shape the person's sitting had given it over enough evenings.

The person sat on the couch and the child was on the floor and the room was the room and neither of them spoke for a while. Not silence — not the silence that is the absence of speaking, not the silence that knows it is silence. Just the room. The child's crayon on the paper. The sound of the crayon — the small wax sound, the soft scratch of color going onto paper, the sound that is underneath every other sound in the room. The person on the couch. The cushion. The sitting. The evening in the window getting darker the way evenings get darker, not all at once but in the way that you notice the lamp is on and you do not remember turning the lamp on but the lamp is on because the room got dark enough that someone turned it on and the someone was the person or the someone was the child and neither of them remembers because the turning-on-the-lamp was the kind of thing that happens in an evening without anyone filing it.

The child said something.

Not to the person — to the room, the way children speak to rooms. The way the child had spoken in the kitchen that morning, calling to the house. Except this was not calling. This was talking. The child said something about the day — something about a person at school, a thing that happened, a thing that was funny or strange or just a thing that happened and the child was telling it because children tell things in the evening when the evening is the evening and the parent is on the couch and the crayon is on the

paper and the telling is what happens in that room at that time on that day.

The person listened. Not the listening from the chapters before — not the ears filing the report, not the hearing-that-does-not-feel-the-words-leave. The person listened the way a person listens to a child talking about the day. Which is to say — the person listened. The child was saying something about someone who had done something and the someone had said something and the child was telling it in the way children tell things, which is not in order, not with the important thing first, not the way a report is filed, but the way a river goes, with the bends and the pauses and the going-back-to-say-the-thing-that-was-before-the-other-thing, the telling that is not for the person's information but for the child's unburdening, the child setting the day down in the room the way the person had set the bag on the bench that morning, putting it where it goes, the telling that is the putting-down.

And the person said something back. Something small. A question. Not a question that needed an answer — the kind of question a person asks when a child is telling a thing and the question says I am here, I am listening, the thing you are saying is landing somewhere. The question was — it does not matter what the question was. The question was the kind of question that parents ask in the evening on the couch while the child is on the floor with a crayon and the evening is getting darker and the lamp is on and the question is not a question. The question is the person being in the room.

The child answered. The child answered the way children answer questions that are not questions — with more telling, with the next part of the thing, with the part that the child had been getting to when the person asked, the part that was the reason the child was telling it in the first place, the part about the thing that happened with the other person's sock.

Someone's sock had come off. At school. During something — the child was not clear about during what, the child was clear about the sock. The sock had come off and the sock had ended up somewhere it was not supposed to be and the children had thought this was very funny and the child was telling the person about the sock because the sock was the thing that was worth telling, the sock was the event of the day, the sock was what Tuesday had given the child to bring home and set down in the room between the couch and the table in the spot where the child set everything down.

The person made a sound. Not the laugh Muhammad asked for — not the involuntary sound the body makes when the body is surprised by its own aliveness. A smaller sound. The sound a person makes when a child is telling a story about a sock and the story is the kind of story that is only funny because the child thinks it is funny and the child thinking it is funny is the thing that is funny, not the sock, the child's face telling about the sock, the child's voice going up at the part where the sock ended up where the sock was not supposed to be, the way children's voices go up when the voice is at the part of the story the voice has been getting to, the part that is the reason for the telling.

The sound the person made was not a laugh. The sound the person made was the sound a person makes in an evening on a couch when a child is telling a story about a sock and the sound is the sound of a person being in a room where a child is telling a story about a sock. The sound was not behind glass. The sound was not in front of glass. The sound was in the room the way the lamp was in the room — on, warm, not remembering when it was turned on.

The child kept talking. The child was past the sock now — the sock was behind and the next thing was ahead and the child was going toward the next thing the way the child had gone toward the morning, the whole body, the whole voice, the telling going

forward without looking back at the sock the way the child had not looked back at the person in the doorway that morning. The child was telling and the person was on the couch and the evening was in the window and the lamp was on and the crayon was on the paper and the room was the room.

The person was in the room. The person was in the room the way a person is in a room in the evening when a child is talking and the lamp is on and the cushion has the shape the person's sitting has given it and the evening is getting darker outside the window and the darker is not the dark from the morning — not the dark-before-the-alarm, not the dark that holds the warmth of the bed — the darker is just the darker, the evening doing what the evening does, the light leaving the way the light leaves, which is slowly, without the leaving being a leaving, just the light going to wherever the light goes when the light is done with the window for the day.

The child was still talking. The person was still

The Morning

The water was running. The person's hand was under it — the left hand, the fingers open, the water going through the fingers and over the palm and down into the sink. The water was not hot yet. The water was the temperature of the pipes, the temperature of the house at the hour before the house wakes, the temperature of water that has been sitting in the pipes all night waiting for someone to turn the handle. The person's hand was under the water and the water was getting warmer and the person was waiting for the water to get warm enough and the waiting was the waiting — not patience, not presence, not the body attending to the water. The person was waiting for the water the way a person waits for the water. The hand under the faucet. The fingers open. The water getting warmer. The getting-warmer that is not sudden but gradual, the way the water lets go of the pipes' temperature and finds the heater's temperature, the way the cold becomes less cold and then

becomes not-cold and then becomes warm and the warm is the warm and the person's hand feels it and the feeling is not a report.

The person filled the kettle. The water from the faucet into the kettle, the weight of the kettle changing as the water went in, the getting-heavier that the hand knew — not by counting, not by watching the water line, but by the weight. The hand knew when the kettle had enough water the way a hand knows when a kettle has enough water, which is by having filled that kettle enough times that the enough is in the hand. The person set the kettle on the burner. The click of the burner. The tick-tick-tick and then the catch and the blue of the flame under the kettle and the person's hand pulling back from the knob because the flame was lit and the hand was done with the knob.

The kitchen was lit. Not by the flame — the flame was under the kettle, the flame was small, the flame was doing what the flame does, which is heat the water. The kitchen was lit by the light that comes before the sun, the light that is in the window at the hour when the sky is not dark and not light but the thing between dark and light, the thing that does not have a name because it does not need a name, the thing that is just the sky doing what the sky does between night and morning. The light was in the kitchen the way the light was always in the kitchen at this hour. The counter was visible. The cups were visible. The dish rack by the sink with the cups in it — two cups, upside down, dry, the cup the person uses and the cup the child uses, both in the rack where they had been since last night, since the person rinsed them and set them there after the evening was done.

The person took the cup from the rack. The person's cup — the one the hand knew, the weight of it, the handle, the way the handle fit the fingers the way the handle had always fit the fingers. The person set the cup on the counter, right side up. The cup was on the counter. The counter held the cup. The person did not think

about the cup or the counter or the holding. The person reached for the coffee.

The coffee was in the canister. The canister was where the canister was — on the shelf, by the window, in the place where the canister had been every morning. The person opened the canister and the smell was the smell — the dark, dry, quiet smell of coffee before the water finds it, the smell that is a promise the coffee does not know it is making, the smell that goes into the kitchen the way the light goes into the kitchen, without asking, without announcing. The person spooned the coffee into the cup. Two spoonfuls. The same two spoonfuls. The spoon going into the canister and the canister holding the coffee and the spoon bringing the coffee to the cup and the cup receiving the coffee and the spoon going back for the second and the second spoonful joining the first and the person closing the canister and setting it back on the shelf in the place where the canister goes.

The kettle was not ready. The water was not hot. The person stood at the counter with the cup that had the coffee in it and the kettle that had the water in it and the flame that was under the kettle and the morning that was in the window and the person stood. The person stood in the kitchen at the counter with the coffee in the cup and the water in the kettle and the flame under the kettle and the light in the window and the two shoes by the door — the person's shoes, the ones the person would put on when the morning got to the part where the person puts on shoes, and next to them the child's shoes, the small ones, the ones that were there from last night because the child had taken them off when the child came in and the shoes had stayed where the shoes had been put, which was next to the person's shoes, by the door, where shoes go.

The person looked at the shoes. Not looked — the person's eyes were on the shoes. The person was standing at the counter and the shoes were by the door and the person's eyes found them

the way eyes find things in a kitchen they have been in enough mornings — without searching, without deciding to look, the eyes just going to where the shoes were because the shoes were there and the eyes were open and the kitchen was the kitchen and everything in the kitchen was where everything in the kitchen always was.

Two pairs of shoes by the door. The person's and the child's. The person's shoes were the person's shoes — the ones the person had worn yesterday and the day before and the day before, the ones that had the shape of the person's feet in them, the wearing-down that was the person's wearing-down, the soles that had walked the sidewalk and the hallway and the block and a half. The child's shoes were the child's shoes — smaller, the laces, the tongue that always folded the wrong way, the shoes that the person had tied yesterday morning and the morning before and the morning before. Both pairs by the door. Both waiting for the morning to get to the part where feet go into shoes and shoes go out the door.

The kettle made the sound. Not the whistle — the kettle did not whistle, the kettle was the kind that made the sound before the whistle, the low sound, the sound of the water starting to move inside the kettle, the sound that said the water was getting close. The person turned to the kettle. The hand went to the handle. The person poured the water into the cup — the water over the coffee, the dark bloom of the coffee meeting the water, the water going dark, the smell changing from the dry smell to the wet smell, the steam coming up from the cup the way steam comes up from a cup, which is slowly, which is the way heat leaves water when the water is too hot to be still about it.

The person set the kettle back on the burner. The person turned the knob and the flame went out and the tick of the metal cooling was the tick of the metal cooling. The person picked up the cup. Both hands. The left through the handle, the right on the body of the cup. The cup was hot. The person held the cup the way

a person holds a cup that is too hot to drink — with the holding, with the waiting, with the hands around the cup feeling the heat come through the ceramic into the palms, the heat that was not the fire and not the water but the thing between the fire and the water, the heat that is what a cup does with the fire and the water, which is hold them both and give the holding to the hands.

The person held the cup and the cup was hot and the steam was in the air and the kitchen was lit and the morning was in the window and the shoes were by the door. The person did not drink yet. The person held the cup the way the person held the cup every morning — standing at the counter, both hands, the heat in the palms, the steam near the face, the waiting that was not waiting for anything but was just the standing-with-the-cup that happens before the drinking, the way there is always a moment before the drinking when the person is just holding the cup and the cup is just being held and neither of them is doing anything yet.

The person was in the kitchen. The cup was in the hands. The morning was in the window. The child was upstairs, asleep, the way the child was asleep at this hour every morning — the sleeping that the person could not hear but knew was happening the way a person knows a child is sleeping in a house, which is by the house being the house, by the quiet being the quiet that has a child sleeping in it, the quiet that is different from the quiet of an empty house but the person could not have said how it was different, only that it was, only that the house with the child sleeping in it was a different house than the house without the child sleeping in it, and the difference was not a sound but a weight, a warmth, a something-in-the-house that was the child being in the house asleep.

The person drank. The first sip. The coffee was too hot and the person drank it anyway the way a person drinks coffee that is too hot — the small sip, the mouth adjusting, the heat on the

tongue that is too much and then is not too much and then is the coffee. The coffee was the coffee. Not the coffee from the chapter before. Not the coffee that was ready before the person was. The coffee was the coffee the person had just made, with the water the person had just heated, in the cup the person had just taken from the rack. The person made the coffee and the coffee was in the cup and the person drank the coffee and the drinking was the drinking.

The person set the cup on the counter. The person walked to the sink. The cutting board — the small one, from the drawer. The bread from the drawer. The knife from the block. The person made the sandwich the way the person makes the sandwich — the bread, the folding, the pressing, the sandwich being done because the hands did the sandwich and the sandwich was done. The apple from the bowl. The blade finding the place by the stem. The halves falling open — the white of them, the wet white, the air finding the white the way air finds the inside of an apple when the blade introduces them. The quarters into the bag. The sandwich into the bag. The bag closed.

And the person reached for the pad. The pad by the phone. The pen by the pad. The person picked up the pen and the hand wrote. Two words. The same two words. The same handwriting. The person did not think about the words. The person wrote the words the way the person wrote the words every morning — the pen on the pad, the letters forming, the words being the words. The person tore the paper. The fold — once, down the middle, the crease under the thumb. The note into the bag.

The person set the bag on the bench by the door. Next to the shoes. Next to the coat hooks. In the place where the morning collects the things the child will carry. The bag was on the bench and the shoes were by the door and the cup was on the counter and the morning was in the window and the person walked back to the counter and picked up the cup and drank again and the coffee

was the temperature the coffee is when the coffee has been sitting for the time it takes to make a sandwich and cut an apple and write a note and put them in a bag. The coffee was the temperature of all of that. The person drank it.

The sound came from upstairs. Not the feet — before the feet. The sound a house makes when someone in the house starts moving. The creak that is not a creak but a shift, the weight of a child rolling over or sitting up or putting feet on the floor above the kitchen. The person heard the sound and the hearing was the hearing. Not the report. Not the filing. The person heard the child moving the way a person hears a child moving in a house in the morning — with the body, with the part of the body that is always listening for the child even when the person is not listening, the part that hears the way the hand knows the kettle, by having heard it enough times that the hearing is not an act but a condition.

The person stood at the counter with the cup. The child would come down. The child would come down the way the child comes down every morning — the feet in the hallway, the appearing in the doorway, the shoe in the hand, the tongue folded the wrong way. The child would stand in the doorway and the person would be at the counter and the cup would be on the counter and the morning would be in the kitchen and all of it would be Tuesday and Tuesday would be Tuesday and the child would hold out the shoe and the person would set down the cup and the person would sit on the step and the foot would go in the lap and the weight would be the weight and the fingers would find the laces and the laces would go through the eyelets and the knot would be the knot and the knot would hold.

The person drank the coffee. The morning was in the window. The child was coming down the stairs.

The door closed behind them and the morning was there.

The child was next to the person. The child's hand was in the person's hand — not because the person had reached for it, not because the child had reached for it, the hands were together the way hands are together when a person and a child walk out a door and the sidewalk is there and the walking has not started yet, the hands finding each other the way the hand found the cup in the kitchen, by being close, by being the thing that is next to the other thing.

The sidewalk was wet. It had rained in the night — the person had not heard the rain, the person had been asleep, but the sidewalk was wet and the wet was the rain's evidence, the rain's note, the rain that had come and gone while the person was sleeping and had left the sidewalk dark and shining in the early light. The child stepped in a puddle. Not on purpose and not by accident — the child stepped in the puddle the way a child steps in a puddle, which is with the foot, which is with the shoe that the person had just tied, the shoe going into the water and the water going over the shoe and the child not stopping, not looking down, not saying anything about the puddle, the child just walking through the puddle because the puddle was where the sidewalk was and the child was walking on the sidewalk.

The person did not say anything about the puddle. The person's hand was in the child's hand and the child's shoe was wet and the knot was wet and the morning was wet and the person kept walking. The block and a half. The same block and a half. The sidewalk the person had walked yesterday and the day before and the day before, the sidewalk that had the crack in it by the third house and the tree root that lifted the concrete by the corner and the place where the sidewalk narrowed by the fence and the person and the child walked single file for three steps — the child in front, the person behind, the hands letting go for the three steps and then finding each other again when the sidewalk widened — and the walking was the walking.

The neighbor was on the porch. The neighbor was always on the porch at this hour — the coffee, the chair, the dog at the feet. The neighbor raised the cup. The person raised a hand. Not a wave — the hand going up and coming back down, the greeting that is not a greeting but a noticing, the acknowledgment that says nothing except: I see you. You see me. We are in the same morning. The neighbor's cup went back to the neighbor's mouth. The person's hand went back to the child's hand. The walking continued.

The corner. The crossing. The other children — the ones who arrive from the other blocks, the ones who come from the other kitchens, the other mornings, the other cups on the other counters. The children converging the way children converge on a school in the morning, which is gradually, which is from all directions, which is the neighborhood producing its children the way the kitchen produced the steam — not all at once, not by announcement, but by the morning getting to the part where the children go to school and the children going.

The person and the child were at the gate. The school gate. The other parents. The other children. The person let go of the child's hand. The letting-go was not a moment — the letting-go was the gate, was the school, was the other children, was the morning getting to the part where the child goes in and the person does not. The child's hand left the person's hand the way the steam left the cup — not by deciding to leave but by the air being there and the steam being steam and the going being what steam does when the cup is open and the morning is warm enough.

The child went through the gate. The child did not look back. Not because the child was brave or independent or had been taught not to look back. The child did not look back because the child was going to school and school was through the gate and the other children were through the gate and the morning was through the gate and the looking-back was not in the child's body. The child's

body was going forward. The child's shoe was wet from the puddle. The knot was holding. The bag was on the child's back with the sandwich and the apple and the note.

The person stood at the gate. The person watched the child go through the gate the way a person watches a child go through a gate — with the watching, with the standing, with the hands that had held the child's hand and tied the child's shoe and written the note and made the sandwich and cut the apple and filled the cup and turned the faucet and stood at the counter in the kitchen in the light before the morning and now the hands were at the person's sides and the child was through the gate and the morning was the morning.

The person turned. The person walked back. The block and a half. The same sidewalk, the same crack, the same tree root, the same narrow place by the fence. The person walked it alone the way the person walked it with the child — with the feet, with the walking, with the body going where the body goes. And the morning was a morning, and tomorrow would be a morning too, and the sidewalk would hold both of them the same way it held this one — without sorting, without knowing which morning the person would be in the warmth and which morning the person would be behind the glass. The neighbor was still on the porch. The cup was still in the neighbor's hand. The dog was still at the feet. The person did not raise a hand. The person walked past. The neighbor did not raise a cup. The morning held both of them without requiring them to acknowledge it again.

The person reached the door. The door was closed. The person opened the door and the kitchen was there — the kitchen the person had left, the kitchen with the cup on the counter, the cutting board, the knife, the canister on the shelf, the kettle on the burner, the flame that was off, the morning in the window. The kitchen was the same kitchen. The kitchen had not changed. The

kitchen had been the kitchen while the person was gone, the way the child was the child while the person was at the counter, the way the morning was the morning while the person was asleep.

The person walked to the counter. The cup was there. The coffee was cold. The person picked up the cup and poured the cold coffee into the sink and rinsed the cup and set the cup in the rack, upside down, next to the child's cup that was already in the rack, the child's cup that the person had rinsed last night. Two cups in the rack. Upside down. Drying.

The person turned off the light. The person picked up the keys from the hook by the door. The person put on the shoes — the person's shoes, the ones by the door, the ones that were there from last night, the ones that did not need anyone to tie them. The person opened the door. The person went through the door. The door closed behind the person and the kitchen was empty and the cups were drying and the morning was in the window and the knife was on the board and the note was in the bag and the child was at school and the person was on the sidewalk and the sidewalk was wet and the morning held all of it — the person walking, the child at school, the neighbor on the porch, the kitchen with its cups, the note the child had not yet found, the knot that was still holding, the puddle the child had walked through, the water that was drying on the shoe, the morning that was Tuesday, the Tuesday that did not know it was the clearing, the clearing that did not know it was Tuesday.